

Boundary Spanning and Individual Performance: The Impact of Self-Monitoring

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Boundary-spanning positions require occupants to interact with groups whose norms may differ from one another. It was hypothesized that individuals holding these positions would perform better if they were sensitive to social cues and able to adapt their behavior to fit the circumstances. Using a sample of 93 field representatives who acted as boundary spanners, it was shown that significant relationships exist between job performance and an individual difference variable (self-monitoring) that assesses the ability of respondents to adjust their self-presentation to fit the situation. It was also shown that self-monitoring was most important during the period of early tenure.

The search for individual difference variables that are related to job performance has had a long and at times unsuccessful history (e.g., Alker, 1972; Bem & Allen, 1974; Guion & Gottier, 1965; Mischel, 1968; Snyder & Monson, 1975). In recent years, criticisms have been made that the measures of so-called "personality constructs" are inappropriate (e.g., Mischel, 1968) and that the amount of variance explained by such variables is small compared with contextual effects (e.g., O'Reilly & Caldwell, 1979; Salancik & Pfeffer, 1978; Saranson, Smith, & Diener, 1975).

Some of the difficulty in using individual difference variables to predict job performance stems from failure to consider contextual effects such as pressures for conformity and informational influence. Two other difficulties originate from attempts to use personality measures without a clear understanding of the nature of the job and a lack of sensitivity to the individual's development in the job. That is, individual differences are assessed without a clear appreciation for why these should directly affect job performance or how these might affect an individual's performance in light of increased job knowledge obtained through experience.

One case in organizations in which success may be related to individual predispositions is that of individuals holding boundary-spanning positions. Boundary spanners serve to filter and transfer information across organizational boundaries (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Tushman, 1977). Individuals responsible for this information transfer may occupy a difficult organizational position. Keller and Holland (1975) argued that much of the reason for this is that boundary spanners have role

senders both inside and outside the organization. These individuals must therefore be able to respond to a variety of informational and social stimuli, both inside and outside the organization. The success of a boundary spanner is, therefore, likely to be influenced by the degree to which individuals can accurately perceive and adapt to a variety of social situations. In short, if an individual is sensitive to and can respond to a variety of possibly divergent social cues, that individual should be more successful in conveying information across organizational boundaries and thus be a more effective performer.

Sensitivity to social cues and the ability to adapt one's behavior to the requirements of the situation have been shown to vary across individuals. Snyder and his colleagues titled this predisposition self-monitoring and developed the Self-Monitoring Scale as a reliable and valid measure of it (Snyder, 1974, 1980). Individuals who are high self-monitors have been shown to be more effective than low self-monitors in (a) concern for the social appropriateness of one's self-presentation; (b) attention to social comparison information as cues to appropriate self-presentation; (c) ability to control and modify self-presentational and expressive behavior; (d) the use of this ability in particular situations; and (e) cross-situational variability in behavior (e.g., Snyder, 1974, 1980). Snyder and Swann (1976), for example, found that whereas strong, positive correlations existed between attitudes and behavior for low-self-monitoring subjects, no significant attitude-behavior correlations existed for high-self-monitoring subjects. High self-monitors, out of concern for the appropriateness of their behavior, modify their behavior to fit the situation, whereas low self-monitors attend less to social cues and rely more on internal beliefs as guides for appropriate behavior. The Self-Monitoring Scale uses items such as,

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"Even if I'm not enjoying myself, I often pretend to be having a good time," and "I laugh more when I watch a comedy with others than when alone," to identify this difference in sensitivity to social cues (Briggs, Cheek, & Buss, 1980; Snyder, 1974).

This individual difference variable appears to be directly relevant to the successful performance of boundary-spanning individuals. First, high-self-monitoring respondents (i.e., those who are able to adapt their behavior to a variety of situations) should be higher performers in their boundary-spanning positions than low-self-monitoring subjects. Second, the impact of self-monitoring should be most evident during the early stages of an individual's job tenure. Comparatively new job occupants who are sensitive to situational cues should perform better than those who are not adept at diagnosing situations. Over time, however, this comparative advantage should be less important as job knowledge increases and/or as low-self-monitoring subjects who are less successful leave the boundary spanning role. The purpose of this study is to explore the relationships among self-monitoring, job tenure, and performance for a sample of job incumbents who occupy a boundary-spanning position.

Method

Subjects

Respondents were field representatives for a large franchise organization. Job duties involved servicing franchised outlets. For example, representatives spent at least 3 days per week contacting franchisees and presenting corporate positions, mediating franchisee-corporate differences of opinion, and referring franchisees to information sources and suppliers. To verify the boundary-spanning and social information processing requirements of the job, a brief job analysis was conducted. Five supervisors were asked to complete a 15-item task checklist for each of three field representative positions they supervised. The 15 items were developed in conjunction with the regional personnel manager. Supervisors were instructed to rate both the importance of and time spent in each task. Evaluation of the similarity of the position analyses is provided by Lawlis and Lu's (1972) nonparametric chi-square. Results of the task analysis indicated high comparability of positions: for time spent, $\chi^2(14) = 159.8, p \leq .001$; for importance, $\chi^2(14) = 277.6, p \leq .001$. Results of the analysis also indicated the relative importance of those items relating to boundary spanning duties. For example, supervisors saw the most important and time-consuming job duty to be that of sharing information with the franchisee.

The 129 field representatives of one geographic

region of the company were surveyed. Usable responses were received from 93 representatives (a response rate of 68%). Average age and tenure with the firm were 30.5 years and 20.2 months, respectively. All but one of the representatives had at least some college education, and 77% had a college degree. Seventy-eight percent of the respondents were male, and 47% were single.

Measures

To test the hypotheses, two constructs were assessed: job performance and attention to social cues. Performance level was obtained from company performance evaluation forms, which provide, in part, a single, overall performance rating. Each field representative was rated on a 4-point scale as excellent, above average, average, or below average. Attention to social cues was measured using the Self-Monitoring Scale. A factor-scoring format was suggested by Briggs et al. (1980), and analyses were conducted using both the overall and factor-scoring protocols. Since the results were nearly identical, only those using the overall scoring format are reported.

Results

Table 1 presents means, standard deviations, and zero-order and partial correlations for all variables. The partial correlations show the association between two of the three variables investigated, with the effects of the third removed (e.g., the correlation between self-monitoring and performance controlling for the effects of tenure). As shown, significant zero-order correlations were found among all variables. Subjects who were more responsive to social cues (high self-monitors) were rated as better performers than low self-monitors. Self-monitoring was also positively related to job tenure.

To examine the independent relationships between self-monitoring, performance, and tenure, partial correlations were computed between self-monitoring and performance controlling for tenure, and between tenure and performance controlling for self-monitoring. Results of these partial correlations show that the association between self-monitoring and boundary-spanning performance is independent of job tenure; that is, boundary spanners who are more sensitive to social cues perform better independent of any job knowledge gained through experience on the job. Interestingly, the significant zero-order correlation between tenure and performance also remains significant after controlling for self-monitoring, suggesting that job experience is independently correlated with improved task performance. Both self-monitoring and job tenure appear to be factors associated with higher performance.

Table 1
Means, Standard Deviations, and Correlations

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	Correlations					
			Zero-order			Partial ^a		
			1	2	3	1	2	3
1. Performance	2.07	.69	—			—		
2. Tenure (months)	20.22	19.36	.27**	—		.23**	—	
3. Self-monitoring	36.16	3.91	.29**	.19*	—	.26**	.12	—

^a Partial correlations are between two variables, controlling for the third.

* $p \leq .05$. ** $p \leq .01$.

To test the second hypothesis (i.e., that the relationship between self-monitoring and performance would be stronger for employees with shorter tenure), moderated multiple regression was used. A hierarchical regression was computed for performance, entering self-monitoring and tenure in the first step and the product of these two variables in the second step. The overall regression was significant, $F(3, 89) = 5.19$, $p < .01$. The main effects of self monitoring, $F(1, 91) = 5.88$, $p < .01$, and tenure, $F(1, 91) = 4.57$, $p < .05$, were significant. The interaction term, although in the hypothesized direction, was not significant ($F = 2.46$). The nature of this interaction was further tested by splitting the sample at the median into high-tenure ($M = 32.5$ months) and low-tenure ($M = 8.2$ months) groups. The correlation between self-monitoring and performance was .31 ($p \leq .01$) for the low-tenure group and .02 (*ns*) for the high tenure group. The difference between these correlations approached significance ($Z = 1.40$, $p \leq .10$). Thus the second hypothesis received slight support and therefore can only suggest that for subjects with shorter tenure, self-monitoring and performance may be related; this was not the case for subjects with longer tenure.

The results of this study are potentially interesting for several reasons. First, the boundary-spanning role places individuals in situations where they must be sensitive to the social cues of different groups if they are to perform the boundary-spanning function effectively. In this study an individual difference variable that precisely captures this required sensitivity (i.e., self-monitoring) was shown to be related to performance. Low self-monitors, those field representatives who were less likely to perceive and adapt their behavior to the situation, performed less well than high self-monitors. The ability of high self-monitors to ad-

just their behavior was associated with high performance ratings and was independent of job experience. These results suggest that individual differences may be associated with actual job performance if the individual difference variable is directly relevant to the task (in this case field representatives who are required to mediate between a corporate office and licensed franchisees). Clearly, under other circumstances one might expect an inverse relationship between high self-monitoring and job performance as, for instance, in positions requiring consistency of behavior regardless of social pressure, such as in the military.

A second interesting finding is the stronger association between self-monitoring and performance that exists for low-tenure, as opposed to high-tenure, job holders. This suggests that prior to obtaining job knowledge through experience, it is in the job holder's interest to be able to perceive and adjust to social cues. Failure to make this adjustment appears to be associated with lower performance for new employees. Once an individual has held the job for a period of time, the impact of self-monitoring is attenuated. This may reflect either the increased skill obtained through experience or a selection bias that results in the retention of employees who are high self-monitors. Some evidence of the latter interpretation is available through an examination of the mean scores for self-monitoring between the low- and high-tenure groups. The low-tenure subsample has a self-monitoring mean of 35.2, whereas the high-tenure group mean is 37.1, $t(91) = 2.36$, $p \leq .01$. The statistically significant partial correlations suggest that both self-monitoring and job tenure make independent contributions to improved performance.

As indicated, the attempt to link personality variables with job performance has had a long, albeit not overly successful, history. Some of this lack of success may result from a failure to link individual difference variables to specific job and situational characteristics that are clearly relevant to job performance. For successful development,

research must focus on those jobs and specific individual difference variables that appear to mediate performance. The present study has demonstrated that performance in a job requiring incumbents to be sensitive to a variety of social cues is associated with individual differences in the ability to perceive and adjust to different settings.

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